



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Brilla College Prep Elementary

School Website: <https://brillaschools.org/our-schools/brilla-college-prep-elementary/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Brilla College Prep Elementary in the Bronx (ZIP 10454) shows partial alignment with classical education, primarily around character formation and virtue-centered aims, but lacks explicit documentation of core classical curricular and pedagogical pillars (Great Books, Trivium fundamentals, Socratic pedagogy, and visible living curriculum practices) in publicly accessible materials. Public-facing materials emphasize virtue-centered education, character development, and college aspirations, with open-admission policies and a focus on a joyful, relationship-rich culture. Taken together with the classical-criteria lexicon, Brilla's materials yield a mixed picture: several positive signals in the realm of character and virtue, but limited evidence of essential classical curricular and pedagogical elements. Overall, the school is best categorized as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Key signals from Brilla materials: - Evidence of virtue-centered aims, character development, and a college-forward formation mindset (positive signals aligned with Virtue, Character, and Formation). These cues align with Positive Keyword indicators in the classical lexicon for Religious/Metaphysical Foundations and School Purpose, though without explicit transcendent metaphysical language or explicit Great Books/Grammars. See citations to Brilla materials describing "academically rigorous and virtue-centered education" and "character development" and "succeed in college and beyond." - Absence (in public materials) of explicit classical curricula (Great Books, grammar/logic/rhetoric sequence as canonical elements), explicit liturgical/theological scaffolding, or Socratic pedagogy—features that would push the classification toward CLASSICAL. See the same Brilla materials showing a focus on virtue and college readiness but not on Great Books or Trivium pedagogy. - Public statements that Brilla is part of a network of several K-8 charter schools with open-access enrollment and a focus on an joyful, relationship-rich culture, which evidences community openness but not the full parent-led, "living curriculum" faculty culture described in classical rubrics. See enrollment/entry-language and "open to all students" language.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 3: School Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: School Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

What would move the needle - Explicitly articulate and implement a classical curriculum framework (grammar, logic, rhetoric) across K-8, with explicit attention to Great Books, primary sources, and liberal arts integration. - Incorporate explicit Socratic pedagogy (dialectic seminars) in upper grades, with structured opportunities for students to engage in reasoned discourse and formal rhetoric training. - Adopt and publicly communicate a formal "living curriculum" concept: faculty as mentors who model virtue, and a clearly defined teacher portrait and student portrait in the classical sense. - Introduce scholē practices (restful contemplation, regular memory work, liturgical or ritual elements that foster reverence and wonder) and clearly describe them on the site. - Extend parent formation and community rituals (book clubs, classical readings, family liturgy alignment) and position parents as co-teachers to align with classical community-building language.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials emphasize virtue-centered education and character formation as central aims. The homepage describes an “academically rigorous and virtue-centered education” and a focus on developing minds and hearts toward character and college readiness.
- The Great Books, theology, liturgical practices, and transcendent metaphysical language are not foregrounded in Brilla’s public materials; the explicit transcendent metaphysical language (truth/goodness/beauty as real) and liturgical practices are not evident on the site itself. The emphasis is on virtue and character rather than theological liturgy.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: virtue, character (and “virtue-centered”). These map to Positive Keyword indicators for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations (virtue, virtuous life, moral realism; and related terms). See Lexicon entries under “Religious and Metaphysical Foundations.”
- Negative keywords: no explicit signals like relativism, secular humanism, or explicitly secular framing appear in the materials.
- Why this rating
- The presence of virtue-centered language and character formation aligns with the virtue-realism side of the tradition, but the absence of explicit theology, liturgy, or transcendent metaphysical framing suggests a partial alignment rather than full classical religious/metaphysical integration. The result is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials emphasize forming minds and hearts toward virtue and preparing students to succeed in college; the focus is on character formation and excellence, not merely job-readiness. The language surrounding “virtue-centered education” and “character development” signals formation as central.
- There is explicit mention of preparing for college and beyond, which is not a classic focus of the classical pedagogy’s telos oriented strictly toward virtue and wisdom; this tilts toward a more modern workforce/college-trajectory emphasis.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, character (per Lexicon: formation, virtue, moral imagination, human flourishing).
- Negative keywords: college and career readiness / workforce emphasis appear as the public aim (to succeed in college and beyond). The Lexicon lists such signals negatively for a fully classical telos. The Brilla messaging leans into college-readiness as a goal.
- Why this rating
- Brilla emphasizes formation and virtue but couples it to a college-ready trajectory, rather than foregrounding the classical telos of wisdom and true goods for their own sake. This mix supports a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL classification.

Element 3: School Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public content emphasizes “academically rigorous and virtue-centered education” and does not foreground the canonical classical curriculum elements (grammar, logic, rhetoric as a living framework; Great Books; Great Conversation; Latin/Greek; or a Trivium/Quadrivium structure). There is no explicit mention of Great Books or a Trivium-based sequence in the public materials.
- The school’s public-facing materials highlight college readiness and character rather than a classical liberal arts curriculum.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: None of the explicit classical curriculum markers (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Great Books; Latin/Greek; Great Conversation) are present in the Brilla public materials. The only related signal is “academic excellence,” but that is generic and not specific to classical curriculum.
- Negative keywords present: terms like “project-based learning” or other modern pedagogy terminologies are not explicitly stated; however, the absence of classical-nuanced curricular markers is the controlling signal here.
- Why this rating
- The curriculum is not described in terms of the liberal arts trivium/quadrivium, Great Books, or a classical canon. Therefore, it does not meet the core Curriculum criteria of a classical program.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- There is no explicit description of Socratic seminars, dialectic, or rhetoric-focused teaching methods in the public materials. The site emphasizes a culture and community orientation and virtue-centered pedagogy, but not the classical pedagogical toolkit (Socratic dialogue, memory work, chant, formal rhetoric training, etc.).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: None of the explicit Pedagogy indicators (Socratic seminar, narration, chanting, memory work, scholé rest, rhetoric exercises) are described on the site.
- Negative keywords present: absence of explicit classical pedagogy signals; however, the lack of classical pedagogy indicators is the main signal for NOT CLASSICAL in this category.
- Why this rating
- The absence of documented classical pedagogy (Socratic method, memory work, chant, etc.) leads to NOT CLASSICAL in this category.

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The school rhetoric centers on virtue-centered education and character formation; faculty are implicitly framed as mentors and role models through the “virtue-centered” mission. The public materials describe a network of schools with a focus on character and excellence, implying a living-curriculum approach (teachers as models) even if not explicitly spelled out as “living curriculum.”
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: virtue, character (and “mentors” as implied by the rhetoric), living curriculum hints (through the emphasis on character formation). This aligns with Positive keyword indicators around faculty as model teachers and mentors and the living curriculum.
- Negative keywords present: none explicit; no signals of “certification-driven jargon without classical context” are present in the public materials.
- Why this rating
- The emphasis on virtue-centered education and character formation suggests a favorable alignment with classical faculty ideals, though explicit articulation of the faculty portrait and living curriculum is not stated. This yields SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The Brilla site advertises family-facing information, open campus visits, and parent involvement through family communications channels (the Families section and operations contact). This demonstrates partnership with families and openness to parental engagement, which aligns with the classical emphasis on parent partnership and community/parent formation.
- The site presents opportunities for parent engagement and schooling information in multiple languages and open access to school visits, which supports the concept of parents as partners and co-teachers in a general sense, even if not explicitly framed in classical language.

- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, co-teachers (in classical lexicon), open campus/parent involvement, family formation (where stated). The Lexicon lists “partnership with parents, co-teachers, parental primacy” and “parent formation” as strong signals for classical community. The Brilla materials include parent and family engagement language and open access to visits, which map to these signals.
- Negative keywords present: none explicit in Brilla materials; no consumer-language framing or minimal parent involvement signals appear.
- Why this rating
- The presence of explicit parent engagement language and openness to parent participation aligns with SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, though it does not fully articulate a rigorous “parent as co-teacher” program in classical terms.

Aggregate Assessment - Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - The school demonstrates partial alignment with classical education through virtue-centered aims, character formation, and active parent engagement, but lacks explicit canonical classical curricular and pedagogical elements (Great Books, Trivium pedagogy, living curriculum, and scholé/restful pedagogy) in its public materials. The six-category snapshot above reflects stronger signals in categories tied to character formation and community engagement, with weaker or absent signals in core classical curriculum and pedagogy categories.

What Would Move the Needle

- Clearly publish and implement a classical curriculum framework (grammar, logic, rhetoric) across K-8, with explicit inclusion of Great Books and primary sources, and a movable-to-progressive plan for Latin/Greek where feasible.
- Adopt and publicly describe explicit classical pedagogies (Socratic seminars, dialectic, narration/recitation, memory work, proscribed project-based learning emphasis) with a structured schedule for grade-level progression.
- Develop and publish a formal “living curriculum” statement and faculty portraits (model teachers, mentors, and living exemplars) to align with the classical Faculty criteria.
- Integrate Scholé practices (restful time, contemplation, wonder) into daily scheduling across all grades, with documented routines and outcomes.
- Elevate explicit references to the true, good, and beautiful (truth, goodness, beauty) in mission statements and curricular aims, including recognition of metaphysical foundations where appropriate.
- Expand and codify parent formation initiatives (reading groups, classical book clubs, family liturgy alignment) and make parents explicit co-teachers with structured involvement and feedback loops.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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